DSEH004 Performance Management and Employee Engagement

Week 10 | Lecture 1 | Unit IV

Designing Mentoring and Coaching Programs

What mentoring does, why formal programs disappoint, and how to design one that works

R K Singh
Senior Professor, Department of Commerce
Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi

Commit before theory

A firm assigns every new manager a senior mentor by algorithm. A year later most pairs met twice. What went wrong most likely?

A

The algorithm matched badly

B

Formal assignment weakens the relationship quality that drives benefits

C

Mentors were too busy

D

New managers did not need mentors

Kram: phases of a mentoring relationship

Initiation

Relationship starts; expectations form

Cultivation

Career and psychosocial functions peak

Separation

Structural or emotional distance grows

Redefinition

A new, more peer-like relationship or an end

Career functions: sponsorship, exposure, coaching, protection, challenge. Psychosocial: role modeling, acceptance, counseling, friendship

What the evidence says about mentoring

Study	Finding	Design implication
Eby et al. (2008)	Mentoring relates to favorable outcomes, but effects are generally small	Set realistic expectations
Ragins and Cotton (1999)	Informal mentees reported more functions and better outcomes than formal mentees	Let participants shape the match
Ragins et al. (2000)	Satisfaction with the relationship mattered more than having a mentor at all	Measure quality, not just pairing
Ensher and Murphy (1997)	Perceived similarity relates to liking and support	Match on goals and values, not only grade

Variants worth knowing

1 Reverse mentoring

Murphy (2012): junior staff mentor seniors, often on technology and culture, building cross-generational learning

2 Coaching

Theeboom et al. (2014) and Jones et al. (2016): workplace coaching has positive effects on individual outcomes

3 Group mentoring

One mentor with several mentees; scales, but with less depth (Course framing)

A program design sequence

Purpose

Which outcome: retention, readiness, inclusion?

Matching

Participant input, shared goals, some choice

Support

Training, protected time, structure for early meetings

Evaluation

Relationship quality and outcomes, compared with a baseline

Mentoring first-generation managers

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Kolkata FMCG company starts a mentoring program for first-time managers from smaller towns. HR matches by department and grade. After six months, mentees say sessions feel like reviews. Mentors get no time allowance. Two mentees asked to switch but were refused.

Work it through

1. Which Kram functions are missing?
2. Diagnose the program with Ragins and Cotton
3. Would reverse mentoring help senior leaders here?
4. Redesign matching and evaluation

Exam-style question

Why do formal mentoring programs often produce weaker results than informal mentoring? Design a formal program that addresses these limits. (20 marks)

What a strong answer does

- Explains Kram's functions and phases
- Uses Eby et al., Ragins and Cotton and Ragins et al. accurately
- Designs matching, support and evaluation around relationship quality
- Considers coaching and reverse mentoring as complements

Sources

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